afraid of world censure in destroying what they saw as heretical monuments. More distant in time, but still fresh in the minds of Shiite Muslims, was the destruction of a holy cemetery in Mecca by like-minded Saudi Wahhabi fundamentalists in 1925. They declared that despite the fact that the Prophet Mohammed's family was buried at the site, veneration there was not explicitly mentioned in the Qur'an and was therefore heretical. In 2013, the ASI banned foreign visitors to Friday prayers in the mosque.[59]

The reality of Sunni fundamentalist threat to India was most prominently on display in 2008, when a militant group struck the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel, burning the building and killing over 30 people. The fact that the building had been named for the Taj and echoed it architecturally in its dome and chhatri corner towers highlighted the fact that it was a symbolic attack against an image of India.[60]

On a daily basis, however, the greatest threats to the Taj are an increasing number of preservation issues. While the building appears indomitable, there are a number of reasons why its stability is threatened. In 2011, it was reported that because of the fact that the Yamuna River was increasingly running dry due to drought, deforestation and water diversion, the mahogany foundation supports were drying out and weakening. In response, cracks were beginning to appear on the building's surface, and the minarets were beginning to tilt on their foundations. The government has established a campaign of reforestation, but the final results are not in yet.[61] Another threat comes in the form of acid rain, specifically due to pollutants created by an oil refinery in Mathura. The acidic quality of the rain erodes the relatively soft marble rock and damages the building's carvings.[62] In 1996, the building was added to the World Monument Fund's "Watch List" due to these problems and chronic mismanagement, but since that time the Fund has reported steady progress in documenting the site and organizing its management.[63]

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